PART III · EXPRESSION · 4

# The pedals

Most pianos have three pedals. The right one, the **sustain pedal**, lifts every damper off the strings, so notes keep ringing after your fingers let go. The left one makes the sound softer.

THE SECRET

**Play first, then change the pedal: up and straight down again.**



**soft pedal**
*una corda*
softer, gentler

**middle pedal**
*sostenuto*
holds only some notes

**sustain pedal**
*damper pedal*
notes keep ringing

*Right pedal: the notes keep ringing*

## What the sustain pedal does




**pedal up: dampers on the strings**

**pedal down: dampers lifted**

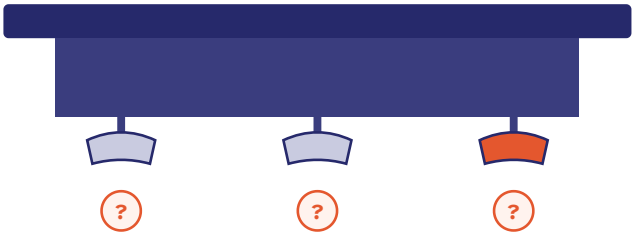
Each string has a felt damper resting on it. Let go of a key and its damper stops the string. The sustain pedal lifts every damper at once, so the strings ring on.

| PEDAL | NAME AND SIGN | WHAT IT DOES |
|---|---|---|
| **left** | soft pedal: *una corda*, written *u.c.* | a softer, gentler sound; lift it at *t.c.* (*tre corde*) |
| **middle** | *sostenuto* *Extra* | holds only the notes already down (on many uprights: a practice mute) |
| **right** | sustain (damper) pedal: *Ped.* | every note keeps ringing until you lift it |

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EXAMPLE 1

**Which pedal?**




1 **Ped.**: which foot pedal? 2 **u.c.**: which one? 3 **t.c.**: what do you do?

Ped. is the **right** pedal; *u.c.* the **left** one; *t.c.* means let the left pedal up.

## Writing the sustain pedal
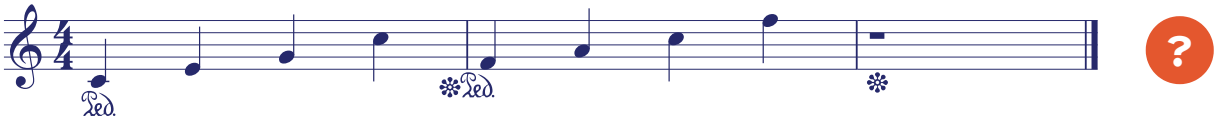
Down at **Ped.**, up at the star, or a line with hooks; six ways are on p. 87.

THE RULE

**Heel on the floor, press with the ball of your foot. Play first, then pedal: new notes, then up and straight down again.**

EXAMPLE 2

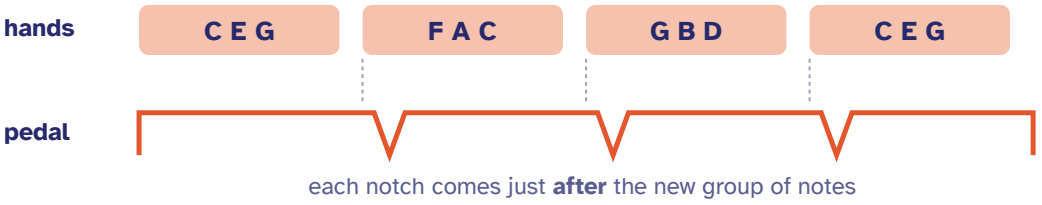
**Where does the pedal go down, and where does it come up?**




1 **Find Ped.** under the first C. 2 **Find the next sign:** a star with Ped. 3 **Find the last star.**

Down on the first C, **changed** at the first F (up and down again), and up at the end: each bar rings as one sound.

## Changing the pedal




each notch comes just **after** the new group of notes

A chord is three or more notes played together. Play each new chord first, then change the pedal straight away.

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## Six ways to write the pedal

| HOW IT LOOKS | ITS NAME | WHAT YOUR FOOT DOES |
|---|---|---|
| *Ped.* ---------- * | **Ped.** ... * | down at Ped., up at the star |
| *Ped.* * *Ped.* * *Ped.* | * **Ped.** under each chord | every new Ped. is a change: up, and straight down |
|  | a line with two hooks | down where it starts, up where it ends |
|  | a line with notches | each notch is a change: up and down again |
| *con Ped. · senza Ped.* | *con Ped. · senza Ped.* | with the pedal (you choose the changes) · without the pedal |
| *Ped. simile* | *Ped. simile* | go on pedalling the same way |

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

### Half pedal and the middle pedal

**Half pedal:** lift the pedal only part of the way, to clear some of the sound but not all. **Sostenuto** (the middle pedal on grand pianos): press it while notes are held, and only those notes keep ringing.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

*Ped.*

### Hear the ringing.

Play C, E and G together, press the right pedal and take your hands off: the chord keeps sounding. Lift the pedal: silence. That is the dampers coming back down.

HOW TO

### Practise the pedal change

1. **Without playing**, say “play, up-down” and move your foot on “up-down”.
2. **Play C-E-G, then F-A-C, then G-B-D**, slowly. Change just after each one.
3. **Listen** for a clean change with no gap of silence.

THINK OF IT The sustain pedal holds a door open: every note that walks in stays until the door shuts.

TRAP

- ✕ Lifting the pedal before the new notes: a gap of silence. Play first, then change.
- ✕ Keeping the pedal down through a new chord: muddy.

SEE ALSO
Touch p. 79 · Chords p. 110

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Library › Pedal